

Active vs Passive

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

Both describe the same event; they just change the focus:

- 1 Active — the doer is the subject (The company hired her). Clear and direct; use it by default.
- 2 Passive — the receiver is the subject (She was hired). Use when the doer is unknown or unimportant.

Prefer the active for clear writing. Reach for the passive to hide or downplay the doer, or to keep the topic in focus.

At a glance

	Active	Passive
Subject	does the action	receives the action
Focus	the doer	the action / the receiver
Example	The chef cooked the meal.	The meal was cooked (by the chef).
Default?	yes — clear and direct	only with a reason

Learning objectives

- Can identify active and passive sentences (CEFR B1).
- Can transform between active and passive in both directions.
- Can justify choosing the passive (unknown/obvious/unimportant doer or focus).

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Active vs Passive · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. Which sentence is PASSIVE?

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|---------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| A. The dog buried the bone. | B. The bone was buried by the dog. |
| C. The dog is burying the bone. | D. The dog buries bones. |

2. Make it passive: 'The gardener waters the plants.'

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| A. The plants are watered by the gardener. | B. The plants water the gardener. |
| C. The plants watered by the gardener. | D. The plants is watered by the gardener. |

3. Make it active: 'The email was sent by Maria.'

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| A. Maria sent the email. | B. The email sent Maria. |
| C. Maria was sent the email. | D. Maria is sending the email. |

4. Which is the better choice: 'Shakespeare wrote Hamlet.'?

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| A. Active — the doer matters and it's clear. | B. Passive — the doer is unimportant. |
| C. Passive — the doer is unknown. | D. Either; there is no difference. |

5. Best sentence when you DON'T know who did it:

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| A. Someone stole my bike. | B. My bike was stolen. |
| C. My bike is stealing. | D. My bike stole. |

6. Which sentence is ACTIVE?

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| A. The window was cleaned yesterday. | B. The results will be published soon. |
| C. The council approved the plan. | D. Coffee is grown in Brazil. |

7. Rewrite more clearly: 'It was decided by us to cancel the trip.'

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| A. We decided to cancel the trip. | B. The trip was decided to be cancelled by us. |
| C. Cancelling the trip was decided. | D. It was us who the trip was cancelled by. |

8. Make it passive (doer unimportant): 'They serve breakfast until 10.'

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| A. Breakfast is served until 10. | B. Breakfast serves until 10. |
| C. Breakfast is serving until 10. | D. Breakfast was served until 10. |

9. Which sentence keeps the topic 'penicillin' in focus?

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| A. Alexander Fleming discovered penicillin. | B. Penicillin was discovered by Alexander Fleming. |
| C. Fleming, in 1928, made a discovery. | D. A discovery was made by Fleming. |

10. When is the ACTIVE voice usually the right default?

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| A. When you want clear, direct writing naming the doer. | B. When the doer is unknown. |
| C. When you want to hide who did it. | D. When the verb has no object. |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **B. The bone was buried by the dog.** — 'was buried' = be + participle, and the bone receives the action.
2. **A. The plants are watered by the gardener.** — Present passive: 'The plants are watered by the gardener'.
3. **A. Maria sent the email.** — The doer (Maria) becomes the subject: 'Maria sent the email'.
4. **A. Active — the doer matters and it's clear.** — Naming Shakespeare matters, so the active is clearer and stronger.
5. **B. My bike was stolen.** — The passive is natural when the doer is unknown: 'My bike was stolen'.
6. **C. The council approved the plan.** — 'The council approved the plan' — the subject does the action.
7. **A. We decided to cancel the trip.** — The active is far clearer: 'We decided to cancel the trip'.
8. **A. Breakfast is served until 10.** — Present passive, doer dropped: 'Breakfast is served until 10'.
9. **B. Penicillin was discovered by Alexander Fleming.** — The passive keeps 'penicillin' as the subject/topic.
10. **A. When you want clear, direct writing naming the doer.** — The active is the clear, direct default that names the doer.